

MATTERS OF FAITH
Actor Prabhas, as seen in a poster of Om Raut's *Adipurush*.

Janaki, *Thank God* has Ajay Devgn playing a dapper Chitragupta who dons black suits and sunglasses, cracks poor jokes, and has women dressed in mini-skirts in his court. Both films stirred up a 'boycott' storm. The *Adipurush* trailer was dogged by controversy over its depiction of Ravan, which some people found uncomfortably reminiscent of Alauddin Khilji in Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Padmaavat* (2018). In addition, BJP leader and Madhya Pradesh home minister Narottam Mishra objected to Hanuman wearing leather, which, according to him, goes against Hindu scriptures. The Vishwa Hindu Parishad soon joined the outcry, and Satyendra Das, the head priest of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, went so far as to demand a ban on the film. In the case of *Thank God*, in addition to being faced with a petition in the Supreme Court seeking a ban on the movie, the makers had to rename Devgn's character 'CG' a few days before the release and thus rework dialogues wherein the word 'Chitragupta' was mentioned, all to ensure that their work is spared further wrath.

Filmmakers are baffled. "*Insaan badlega toh chalega, bhagwaan kaise badal gaya* [Man can evolve, but not God]," says Indra Kumar, the director of *Thank God*. "*Bhagwaan ko ijaazat nahin hai badalne ki* [Gods have no right to change]. We humans decide whether they can change." Kumar has been making films for 32 years, including the popular *Masti* (2004, 2013, 2016) series. But never has he seen such vitriol being spewed at his work. "My film is not about *dharma* [faith], it is about *karma*," says Kumar. "You have forced faith into the film. I want to show *bhagwaan bhi* cool *hai* [the gods are also cool]. The film is about how people should save themselves from the seven sins."

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– INDRA KUMAR
Director,
Thank God (2022)

